# Story App — v1 Product & Design Spec

Oct 19, 2026 · @Utsav Pandya

## Concept and decisions

The app turns a one-day trip into a scrapbook-style story: each place is a chapter, and the route between places is the thread that ties them together. The user adds stops, photos and their own words; the app lays it out as an interactive story in-app and exports it as a PDF keepsake.

Working example: Chhatrapati Shivaji Terminus → Sardar Pav Bhaji → Siddhivinayak Temple → hotel check-in, Mumbai.

| Decision | Choice for v1 |
|---|---|
| Platform | iOS, SwiftUI |
| Trip scope | Single-day trips only |
| Output | In-app interactive story + PDF export |
| Interactivity | Tap a stop or a route segment to open the story behind it (in-app only; the PDF is the static version) |
| Photo source | Camera or photo library |
| Story text | Written by the user; AI writing comes in a later version |
| Map | Both: a real map overview page plus an illustrated dashed route flowing through the story pages |
| Finding a place | Auto-detected from photo GPS, with place search as fallback |
| Travel between stops | User picks transport mode and enters km and minutes |
| Layout | Auto-generated from templates, no freeform editor |
| Themes | One theme for v1: Vintage Kraft |

The guiding principle: **the route is the spine of the story**, not a map with photos attached.

# Data model

Three entities: a **Journey** holds ordered **Stops**, and a **Leg** connects each pair of consecutive stops. Legs are first-class because tapping a route segment must open a story of its own ("the taxi driver who knew a shortcut").

### Journey

| Field | Required | Notes |
|---|---|---|
| Title | Yes | "A Day in Mumbai" |
| Date | Yes | Defaults to the date of the first photo |
| City | No | Auto-filled from the first stop |
| Cover photo | No | Defaults to the first stop's hero photo |
| Intro note | No | One or two lines shown on the cover page |
| Closing note | No | Shown on the final page |

### Stop

| Field | Required | Notes |
|---|---|---|
| Place name | Yes | From GPS detection or search; editable |
| Story | Yes | The user's paragraph, the heart of the page |
| Location | No | Coordinate + address; needed for the map, so a stop without one is left off the map |
| Arrival time | No | From photo timestamp, editable |
| Time spent | No | Shown as "spent 45 min" |
| Photos | No | 0–4; one marked as hero |
| Category | No | Food, landmark, temple, stay, shopping, nature, other; drives the stamp icon |
| Highlight | No | One short line rendered as a highlighter strip: "best butter pav of my life" |
| Rating | No | 1–5, shown as a stamped rating |
| Review | No | Short verdict, separate from the story |
| Cost | No | Amount + currency, e.g. ₹180 |

| Field | Required | Notes |
|---|---|---|
| Tip | No | Advice for future visitors: "go before 7 pm, the queue doubles after" |
| Mood | No | One of a small set (joyful, calm, tired, amazed); a small doodle on the page |

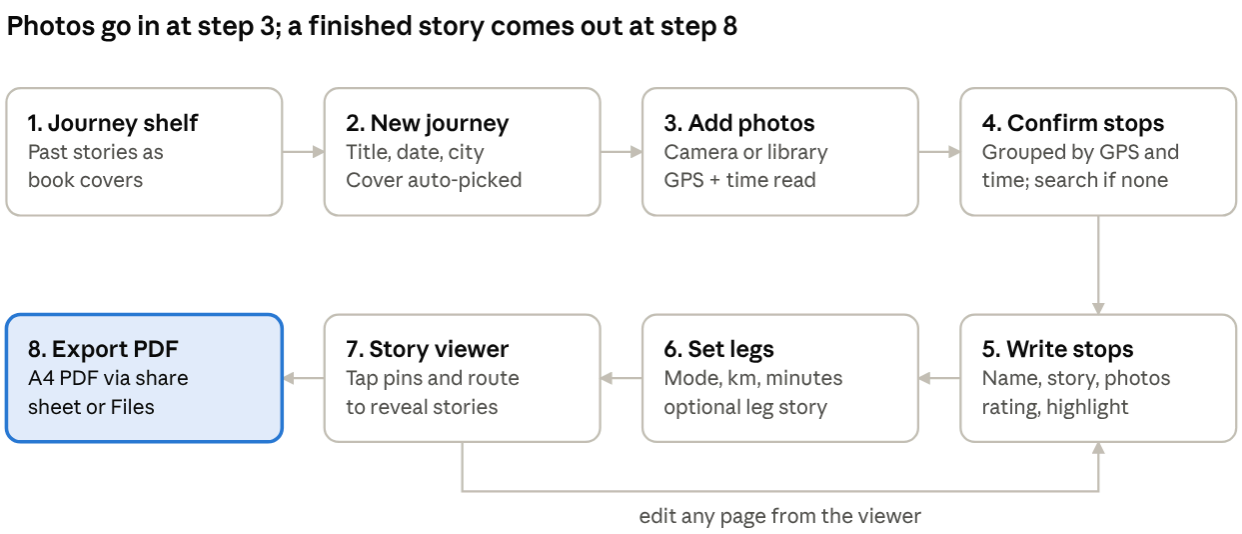
**Leg** (between stop N and stop N+1)

| Field | Required | Notes |
|---|---|---|
| Transport mode | Yes | Walk, auto-rickshaw, taxi/cab, bus, local train, metro, bike, ferry |
| Distance | No | km, entered by the user; the app pre-fills a suggestion where it can |
| Duration | No | Minutes, entered by the user; pre-filled the same way |
| Leg story | No | A short note that pops up when the route segment is tapped |

Fields beyond name and story are suggestions for v1; Mood and Tip are the first candidates to cut if scope gets tight.

## App journey

A new story takes eight screens, and the viewer loops back to editing until the user is happy.




v1 app journey · 8 screens, 1 edit loop

Permissions are asked in context, not at onboarding: photo library at step 3, location only if the user opens the map search. Stops without GPS land in step 4 as "Find this place" and use search.

## Story output

One layout engine renders both outputs: the in-app story is the interactive version, and the PDF is the same pages printed flat. Pages follow a fixed sequence.

1. **Cover** — journey title in script, date and city, a collage of 3 hero photos, and an auto-generated postmark stamp ("ARRIVED · 19 OCT 2026 · MUMBAI").
2. **Route overview** — a real map in sepia/paper style with numbered stamp pins and the route line, plus a stats strip: 4 stops · 8.4 km · 5 h 20 min · walk, taxi.
3. **Stop pages** — one per stop: hero polaroid, supporting photos with washi tape, the story on a torn note card, highlight strip, rating stamp and review, place ticket with name and category.
4. **Leg connectors** — between stop pages, the dashed route continues off one page and onto the next, with a mode icon and "taxi · 18 min · 5.2 km".
5. **Closing page** — "The day in numbers" (stops, km, minutes, money spent, photos) and the closing note.

### In-app interactions

- Swipe horizontally between pages like a book.
- Tap a pin on the overview map → jump to that stop's page.
- Tap a route segment on the map or a leg connector → a card pops up with the leg's mode, km, minutes and leg story.

- Tap a photo → full-screen view.
- Edit button on any page → opens that stop's editor.

**PDF**

- A4 portrait as the default page size; square (Instagram) export is an open question.
- Leg stories, which are pop-ups in the app, print as small note cards beside the connector.
- Shared through the iOS share sheet or saved to Files.

## Features

v1 proves one loop: photos in, a story you're proud of out. Everything else waits.

| Feature | Version |
|---|---|
| Journey shelf (list of stories as book covers) | v1 |
| Create journey: title, date, city | v1 |
| Add photos from camera or library | v1 |
| Auto-group photos into suggested stops by GPS and time | v1 |
| Detect place name from photo GPS; search fallback | v1 |
| Stop editor with all Stop fields | v1 |
| Leg editor: mode, km, minutes, leg story | v1 |
| Reorder and delete stops | v1 |
| Auto-layout story in Vintage Kraft theme | v1 |
| Route overview map page | v1 |
| Interactive story viewer with tap-to-reveal legs | v1 |
| PDF export + share sheet | v1 |
| Drafts saved on device, works offline (except place lookup) | v1 |
| Pick hero photo and layout variant per stop | v1.1 |
| Pre-filled km/minutes from route calculation | v1.1 |
| Square export for Instagram carousel | v1.1 |

| Feature | Version |
|---|---|
| Extra themes: Sunny Tropical, Sketchbook | v2 |
| Multi-day trips with day chapters | v2 |
| AI: turn rough notes into story prose in the user's voice | v2 |
| Share as a web link | v2 |
| Live trip mode with background location | Later |
| Freeform scrapbook editor with stickers | Later |
| Order a printed book | Later |
| Collaborative journeys with friends | Later |

## Design system: Vintage Kraft

The scrapbook is the output, not the UI. Story pages use the full Vintage Kraft look; editing screens stay calm (cream background, ink text, system controls) so they never compete with the story.

**Colour**

| Token | Hex | Use |
|---|---|---|
| paper | #F3EBDD | Page background, app background |
| paperDeep | #E6D9C3 | Cards on paper, secondary surfaces |
| kraft | #C9A97E | Kraft cards, ticket stubs, tape |
| kraftDark | #8B6B4A | Borders, stamp outlines |
| ink | #2B2420 | Primary text |
| inkSoft | #5E5249 | Secondary text, captions |
| route | #9E3B2F | Dashed route line, arrows, pins |
| sealRose | #B5838D | Wax seal, hearts, accent buttons |
| stampTeal | #3E6B6A | Postmarks, category stamps |
| highlight | #F2D06B at 70% | Highlighter strips behind short lines |

**Type** (all Google Fonts, OFL licensed, bundled in the app)

| Role | Font | Size |
|---|---|---|
| Journey title | Allura (script) | 44 pt |
| Stop name | Allura | 30 pt |
| Story body | Lora (serif) | 16 pt, 24 line height |
| Annotations, captions, highlights | Caveat (handwriting) | 18 pt |
| Labels, stamps, stats | Special Elite (typewriter), uppercase, +1.5 tracking | 11 pt |
| App UI controls | SF Pro (system) | Dynamic Type |

### Textures and assets

- Paper grain background (tileable, subtle)
- Torn-edge masks for note cards (3 variants)
- Washi tape strips: plain kraft, pink grid, floral (3 variants)
- Polaroid frame, perforated postage-stamp frame, round postmark, wax seal, paper clip
- Category stamp icons: food, landmark, temple, stay, shopping, nature
- Transport icons in ink-line style: walk, auto-rickshaw, taxi, bus, train, metro, bike, ferry

### Components

| Component | What it shows |
|---|---|
| Polaroid | Photo + Caveat caption, rotated slightly |
| Taped photo | Photo held by one or two washi strips |
| Note card | Torn-edge paper holding the story text |
| Highlight strip | Short line on a highlighter band |
| Place ticket | Ticket stub: place name, category stamp, arrival time |
| Postmark | Round stamp with stop number and time, or date and city on the cover |
| Rating stamp | Stamped stars + one-line review |
| Leg connector | Dashed route, arrowhead, mode icon in a circle, "18 min · 5.2 km" |

| Component | What it shows |
|---|---|
| Route map card | Sepia map snapshot, numbered pins, route line, stats strip |
| Stats strip | Typewriter row of totals |

**Layout rules**

- Each stop page picks a template by photo count (0, 1, 2, 3, 4).
- Elements rotate between −4° and +4°, seeded by the element's id so the app and PDF always match.
- At most 2 tape strips per photo; at most 1 wax seal per page.
- The route line always enters a page from the previous page's exit side, so pages read as one continuous path.
- Margins: 24 pt on phone, 36 pt on the PDF page.

## Tech notes

Everything in v1 runs on Apple frameworks, with no backend.

| Need | Approach |
|---|---|
| Persistence | SwiftData models for Journey, Stop, Leg; photos stored as files, referenced by path |
| Photo picking | PhotosPicker for library, a camera sheet for capture |
| Photo GPS and time | Read the PHAsset location and creationDate (needs library access), or the image's EXIF metadata |
| Grouping into stops | Cluster photos by distance (about 150 m) and time gap (about 30 min); thresholds to tune with real trips |
| Place name from GPS | MKLocalPointsOfInterestRequest near the coordinate, falling back to reverse geocoding for an address |
| Place search fallback | MKLocalSearch with the city as region |
| km / minutes suggestion (v1.1) | MKDirections for walk and drive; the user's entry always wins |

| Need | Approach |
| --- | --- |
| Overview map | MKMapSnapshotter, then a sepia filter, paper texture overlay, and route and pins drawn on top |
| Story pages | SwiftUI views per page; rotation and tape positions seeded by ids so renders are repeatable |
| PDF export | ImageRenderer rendering each page view into a PDF context |

Risk to check early: photos saved from the internet or WhatsApp often lose GPS data, so the search fallback will be used more than expected.

## Open questions and next steps

- [ ] App name: working candidates Trailbook, Wayfolio, Storyroute
- [ ] PDF page size: A4 portrait only, or also square for Instagram?
- [ ] Story length: set a soft limit (about 120 words) so pages never overflow?
- [ ] Keep or cut Mood and Tip fields for v1
- [ ] Mock up the key screens: shelf, stop editor, leg editor, story viewer
- [ ] Build a throwaway prototype of one stop page + PDF export to validate the look early